

Blue Team Script

(Speaker 1): Introduction

Good afternoon, everyone. Today, we will be presenting our topic: * If there is a moral right to abortion, then there is a moral right to sex-selective abortion, even if it is carried out with the intention of choosing a child of a certain sex. * I am Speaker 1 and I will be presenting on why we agree with the statement by presenting **two key premises**. Speaker 2 and Speaker 3 will provide supporting reasonings for each premise, followed by Speaker 4 who will be providing counterarguments to possible objections. (Next Slide)

In many societies, economic and cultural factors shape family decisions about childbirth. While sex-selective abortion is often criticized, it can be seen as a rational and beneficial choice in certain contexts. We fail to take into account certain family demographics that treats sex selective abortions as a necessity for the future wellbeing and financial stability of the family,

1. Economic Stability and Family Well-Being

In societies where sons are traditionally responsible for financial support and caregiving for elderly parents, families view having a male child as an economic necessity. In agrarian communities, sons contribute to farm labor and secure long-term family wealth, while daughters, upon marriage, often leave their birth families, offering little financial return. In countries without strong social welfare systems, having a son ensures financial security and reduces hardship in old age.

Beyond economics, cultural traditions often dictate family expectations. In many patriarchal societies, male children carry the family name, inherit property, and perform essential religious rites like in China and Hindu communities in India. The inability to produce a male heir can bring social stigma, emotional distress. By choosing sex-selective abortion, families can prevent family conflict, social ostracization, and potential marital instability.

Before we begin, here is something to ponder: In societies where a child's gender is stigmatized, would being raised in such an environment be good for their well-being?

Our first premise is that: If abortion is morally justified for **any** reason, then it should be morally justified for **all** reasons, including sex selection.

This argument is supported by **utilitarianism**, which holds that the morally right action is the one that produces the greatest overall good.

Our second premise is that Abortion is morally justified in situations where it addresses the needs or circumstances of the family, such as health concerns, socio-economic stability, or the ability to care for the child. It will be supported by **virtue ethics**, which emphasizes moral character, practical wisdom (*phronesis*), and the pursuit of a flourishing life

I will now pass on the time to nessa to elaborate more.

(Speaker 2:): Premise 1 - Inconsistency in Reproductive Decision-making

Thank you, Speaker 1. Now, I will present our first premise: If abortion is morally justified for any reason, then it should be morally justified for all reasons, including sex selection.

This argument is based on logical consistency, practical consequences, and ethical reasoning. If abortion is permitted for financial hardship or career aspirations, then prohibiting it solely for sex selection is inconsistent and arbitrary.

1. Inconsistency in Moral and Legal Reasoning

Society permits abortion for reasons such as financial hardship, personal aspirations, or family circumstances. If these reasons are considered valid, then prohibiting abortion solely for sex selection creates an inconsistency in reproductive decision-making.

Laws governing abortion should be applied consistently, either all personal reasons for abortion are acceptable, or they are not. Isolating sex selection as an exception while allowing other personal motivations contradicts the broader acceptance of reproductive choice and decision-making autonomy.

Reproductive choices already extend beyond just abortion. Parents can use IVF to select embryos based on health conditions or genetic traits. If this is acceptable, why should selecting a child's sex be different?

2. Practical Consequences of Banning SSA

Beyond inconsistency, banning SSA has real-world consequences that cause more harm than good.

A key example is India, where the Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (PCPNDT) Act of 1994 banned SSA to reduce gender imbalance. However, instead of solving the issue, it led to unintended consequences:

Banning SSA has led to several harmful consequences. Women seeking SSA have turned to illegal and unregulated procedures, putting their health at serious risk. Additionally, the fear of legal repercussions has made doctors hesitant to perform any abortions, even those unrelated to sex selection. This issue is particularly severe in rural areas, where the access to healthcare is already limited. Furthermore, some families, unable to abort female fetuses, have resorted to infanticide—the killing of newborn daughters—or severe neglect, depriving girls of proper care, education, and nutrition. Rather than reducing gender bias, the ban has driven these harmful practices underground, exacerbating the problem.

A better solution would be addressing the root cause—gender bias—through education, economic support, and social reform. Instead of banning SSA, we should ensure that families don't feel pressured to prefer sons in the first place.

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3. The Role of Ethical Theories

Now, let's examine SSA bans through a utilitarian perspective.

Utilitarianism is the ethical theory that prioritizes maximizing well-being and minimizing harm. If abortion is allowed because it reduces suffering, such as financial hardship, then banning SSA contradicts this logic. The ban does not stop SSA but increases suffering through unsafe abortions, restricted reproductive rights, and harm to female children. A truly utilitarian approach would focus on education and social change, not restrictive laws that backfire.

Conclusion

Banning SSA does not eliminate gender bias—it only pushes the issue underground and creates greater harm. If abortion is justified for personal or financial reasons, banning SSA is inconsistent with utilitarian logic.

A better solution is tackling gender bias directly through education, economic empowerment, and social reform—not restrictive laws that backfire. If ethics is about well-being, banning SSA fails the test.

Now, I will pass the time over to Ewen, who will present our second premise.

(3rd Speaker) :

Now moving on to the second **Premise**, which is **parents having the right to decide the characteristics of their family based on personal preferences**. One important idea here is **Virtue Ethics**, particularly Aristotle's belief in **Eudaimonia**, which refers to human flourishing or living the best life possible. According to Aristotle, ethical decisions should promote long-term well-being and happiness for both individuals and families.

In the context of sex-selective abortion, if parents believe that having a child of a specific gender will lead to a happier and more harmonious family life, then virtue ethics supports their right to make that decision. Forcing parents to have a child of an undesired gender, especially in societies where strong gender biases exist, may create resentment, emotional distress, and family conflicts. These negative outcomes go against the goal of achieving flourishing lives.

Another key concept is **Practical Wisdom**. This refers to the ability to make thoughtful and responsible decisions based on specific circumstances. Parents are often in the best position to evaluate their readiness and family situation, including financial stability, emotional preparedness, and cultural considerations. Trusting them to make thoughtful reproductive choices reflects virtues like responsibility, compassion, and care for the well-being of their family.

We also need to think about the **well-being of children**. If parents are forced into raising a child they did not wish for due to gender expectations, it could negatively affect the child's upbringing and emotional development. A virtue ethicist might argue that avoiding such situations promotes compassion and love, which are essential for a child's growth and well-being.

Finally, it's important to acknowledge the **influence of social norms**. In some communities, traditions shape preferences for family composition. For example, certain families prioritize having a son to carry on the family name, while others see having a daughter as vital to family harmony. Ignoring these values may lead to unnecessary tension and disrupt family dynamics.

In conclusion, virtue ethics teaches us that ethical decisions should promote flourishing for both parents and children. By respecting parental choices and trusting them to act with practical wisdom, we encourage responsible and compassionate decision-making, leading to stronger, healthier families.

(Speaker 4): Objections

Thank you. Now that we have presented our case, I will address some of the strongest objections against our position. Our first objection is Moral Distinction Between Sex-Selective Abortion and Other Forms of Abortion

While abortion may be morally justified in cases involving health concerns, socio-economic stability, or the ability to care for a child, sex-selective abortion raises different moral questions. Selecting a child's sex, especially if done to favor one gender over another, could be seen as reinforcing gender discrimination, contributing to societal imbalances, and perpetuating harmful cultural norms. The moral justification for abortion in these other circumstances doesn't necessarily extend to sex-selective abortion, as it may be viewed as unjustly treating one gender as less valuable than another.

Response: One could argue that the right to choose an abortion is primarily about the autonomy of the pregnant person to make decisions in the best interest of their family, regardless of the reasons. If the fundamental justification for abortion is the well-being of the family or the individual, then why the abortion is being sought (even in cases of sex selection) should not necessarily be the focus, as long as the decision does not harm others outside of the immediate family. Moreover, it's important to differentiate between individual choices and systemic gender issues, which may require separate solutions, such as education

or legal measures to prevent discrimination rather than restricting personal choices.

Objection 2: Slippery Slope to Other Forms of "Eugenic" Abortions

If sex-selective abortion is morally justified under the reasoning that it aligns with broader abortion justifications, it could set a dangerous precedent. It might lead to the acceptance of abortions based on other "non-essential" criteria, such as disabilities, intelligence, or appearance. This could be seen as a form of eugenics, where society starts to value certain characteristics over others, leading to a devaluation of human life based on subjective preferences.

Allowing sex-selective abortion could, therefore, erode the ethical boundaries for abortion in general, and this could have long-term societal consequences.

Response: The concern about a slippery slope is valid but does not necessarily apply to all cases of abortion. The justification for sex-selective abortion can be carefully distinguished from other potential "eugenic" abortions by focusing on the fact that such decisions are deeply personal and specific to the individual or family's context. While it's essential to prevent harmful forms of discrimination, the overall goal should be to protect reproductive rights and personal autonomy. It's also worth noting that most legal systems already place limitations on what constitutes a morally acceptable reason for abortion. These boundaries can be maintained, and the moral justification for abortion can be more nuanced, addressing the complexity of individual situations while avoiding a descent into eugenics.

Conclusion:

Let's sum up what we had presented.

It is given , Abortion is considered acceptable in certain situations, like when families face financial difficulties or when parents feel they are not ready to raise a child.

Premise 1: If abortion is allowed for these reasons, then it should also be allowed for sex selection. All reproductive choices should be treated equally without judging which reason is "better" or "worse." Choosing a child's gender is just another form of personal preference, like choosing the number of children to have or when to have them.

Premise 2 is based on Virtue Ethics, which focuses on long-term happiness and flourishing. Aristotle believed that good decisions lead to well-being for everyone involved. Parents know what's best for their family. Giving them the freedom to choose the characteristics of their family, including the child's gender, can help create a more harmonious, happy household.

In conclusion,sex-selective abortion should be supported, as it aligns with both moral consistency and the ethical principle of virtue ethics.